DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Do We Decide Whether God Shines or Hides?

Daat Tevunot §78-79

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §78 (second half) to §79 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Tuesday 31 January 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Where we are

We are halfway through §78 (page 170 in the English). Last time we learned that the body comes from hester, God's concealment, and the soul from hearah, His illumination. The Ramhal now applies this to the world around us.

What are people running after?

The Ramhal asks us to look at the world and at the difference between earlier and later generations. People run back and forth from morning to night without rest. For what? For a world that passes so quickly: "today we're here and tomorrow we're in the grave". We were not created for this. Our main concern should be to understand the glory of God, and we were given wisdom for that, not only to increase our trade. Because of the sin of Adam we must engage in these things, but they are not the goal.

In every generation the world falls further in this. The earlier generations were closer to wisdom; the later ones are sunk in business and work that has no end product.

Measure for measure

The reason, the Ramhal explains, goes back to body and soul. The body was created through concealment, so its existence is dark and clouded, and it is mortal. The soul was created through illumination, so it is immortal. If a person strengthens his body over his soul, then measure for measure God deals with him through concealment. "If that's what you allow to win, then fine," and he moves further from wisdom into the pollution of materialism.

That is what happened to Adam and his descendants. Adam and Havah followed what was pleasing to their eyes and let the body control the soul. So God, as it were, concealed Himself in return: "by the sweat of your brow you shall eat bread". From then on, we are always working. In Gan Eden, Adam would have had illumination, with body and soul living in harmony.

The child and the wine

The Ramhal gives a rule: the limits of a person's intellect are reflected in his thoughts and desires. A young child does not understand wisdom and has no desire for it. He runs out of school to play, in the Ramhal's day with pebbles, the Rabbi added, today with phones and video games. As the intellect grows, a person comes to appreciate more refined things.

The Rabbi gave a physical example. Give wine to a child and he does not appreciate it. As you get older you learn to appreciate different wines. So too with the intellect: the greater it becomes, the less a person desires physical things. When humanity was influenced by great illumination, people wanted only wisdom and what is truly good. Without it, they pursue the pleasures of this world.

This illumination departed from mankind after the sin of Adam. At Matan Torah, the Gemara says, Israel returned to the state of Adam before the sin, but after the golden calf the world grew dark again. Yet when a person lets his soul override his body, God illuminates him too, and the righteous become greater than angels, as in the time of Hanokh, and as it will be in the future: "I will pour out My spirit on all flesh". Some generations, like those of Moshe, David and Shelomoh, had great illumination.

How much depends on us

The Ramhal concludes that once we see how body and soul reflect illumination and concealment, we understand why the world is sometimes concealed and sometimes illuminated, and how great man is: everything depends on him. When we use the Neshamah over the body we bring illumination into the world; when we do not, we bring concealment.

The Rabbi tied this to the verse "Hashem is your shade" and to what they learned in Derech Hashem about hashgahah. People ask whether God is involved in their lives. "Well, it really depends on you." A person who lives with complete materialism can have that: God leaves him to what looks like randomness, sometimes good and sometimes bad. A person who wants illumination and connection empowers the Neshamah over the body, and with it hearah over hester.

He applied it to today. The world is so material, and there is less and less intellect, in the Torah world and the secular world alike. "Where are the next great scientists going to come from" when children can barely concentrate for half an hour? Fifteen or twenty years ago good yeshivah students commonly learned for six hours straight; today, with gadgets everywhere, that is much harder. That too is the concealment growing.

Question: isn't the soul's creation also a concealment?

Mark asked a sharp question. Anything God creates must involve some concealment, since nothing can come from His full emanation. So is the soul simply a stronger emanation and the body a weaker one, or is there an inherent difference?

The Rabbi called it an excellent question. First, when we speak of the soul coming from God we never mean God Himself, which is the Or Ein Sof. We mean His modes, as when we call Him merciful. The soul, like the angels, comes through a chain of levels that traces directly

back to the light. The body is not made that way; it is made by holding something back and letting existence arise within that void.

The group discussed whether the difference is that the body comes from the earth. Mark suggested that being made from something else, from the earth, is the concealment within us that lets us make problems for ourselves. The Rabbi said he would have to think about it, but that it makes sense: "it has to be more than just further down the chain, because clearly it's two different modes", like light, which is formed, and darkness, which is created through withdrawal. "Our problem is our connection to the physical, which is the earth. That is our yeser."

Others returned to whether souls differ, since babies are born with different personalities and abilities. The Rabbi agreed that people are born with different wisdom and talents, but said intellect is not the measure of the Neshamah. It is important, "but it's not everything". There are simple people whose purity of service is extraordinary.

§79: man as a microcosm

The Neshamah says: this makes sense, and I see great wisdom in how God's modes are interlinked. Just as the world has illumination and concealment, so does the human being, in soul and body. Man is a microcosm of the world. The Ramhal will develop this in the next paragraphs.

Summary

- The body comes from concealment and is mortal; the soul comes from illumination and is immortal.
- Measure for measure, a person who lets the body rule is dealt with through concealment, as happened after the sin of Adam.
- The more the intellect grows, the less we desire physical things, like a child who learns to appreciate wine.
- Our choices bring illumination or concealment into the world: "Hashem is your shade".
- §79: man is a microcosm of the world, a combination of illumination and concealment.

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